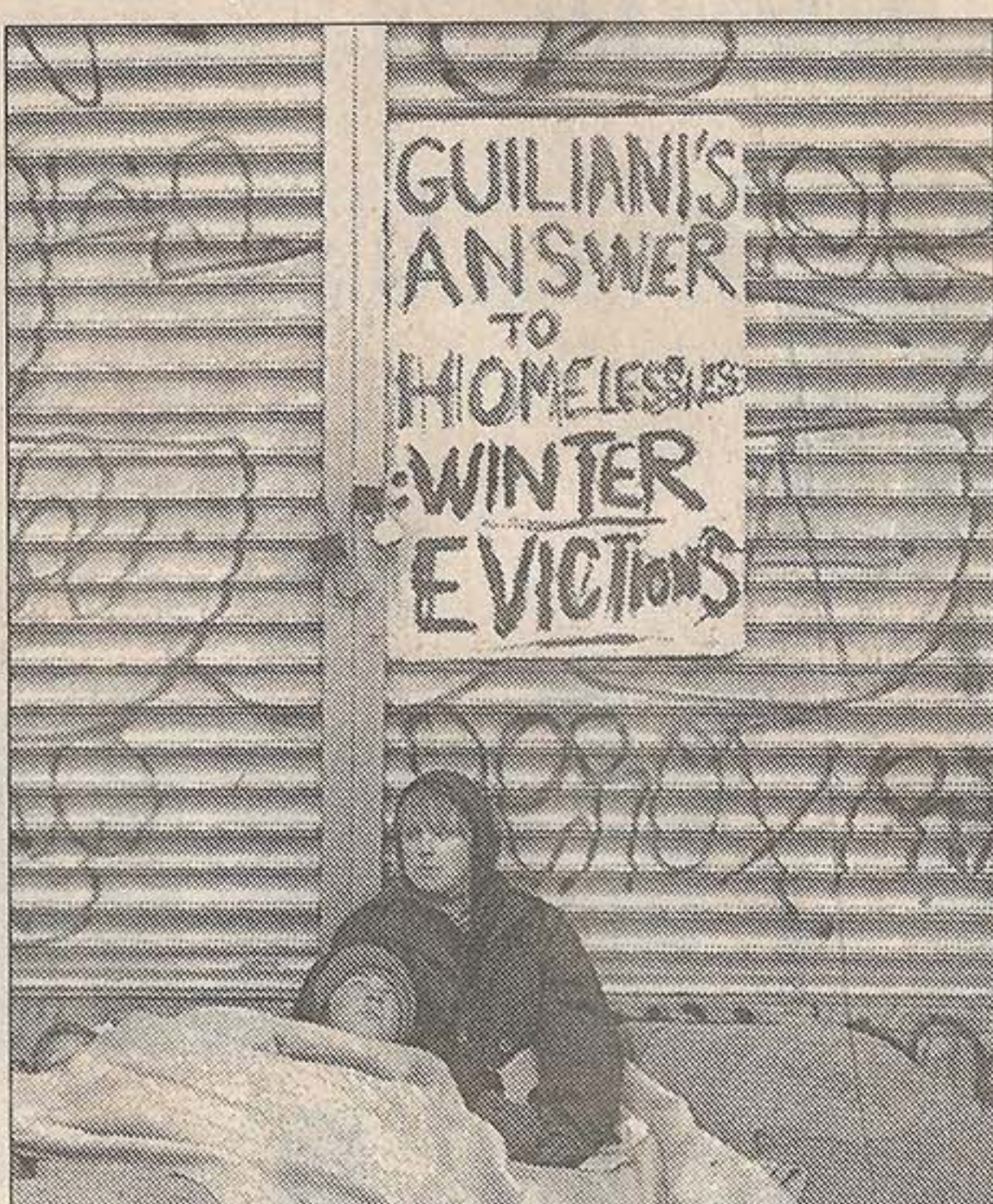


S O A P B O X

**Their Home No More**

Melissa Smith, 18, left, and Angela Hubbard, 22, outside the Glass House on Avenue D after they and 33 other squatters were evicted to make way for housing for AIDS patients planned for the building.

In the Glass House

**'It's Given Me a Lot of Self-Esteem':
Voices of a Squatter Community on the Lower East Side**

Text and Photographs by MARGARET MORTON

ON Feb. 1, the police evicted a community of 35 young squatters, along with an equal number of their pets, from an abandoned glass factory, known as the Glass House, on the corner of Avenue D and 10th Street in Manhattan. Most of the squatters ranged in age from 17 to 21 and had moved from the Midwest, only to find themselves jobless and homeless in New York. Several had spent their childhoods in communes, and they gravitated to the street life of the Lower East Side and eventually to the Glass House.

Over a period of four months before their eviction, I

Margaret Morton, a documentary photographer, is an associate professor at the Cooper Union School of Art.

spent many days in the Glass House, photographing and interviewing the squatters. I found that, contrary to what I might have expected, they had created a supportive, responsible community.

Electricity was brought in from the corner street-light. Toilets were installed, using water drawn from a fire hydrant. Food was collected during nightly raids on Dumpsters outside restaurants.

Newcomers literally worked their way into the community: before they could petition for a set of keys at the weekly house meeting, they had to prove that they could construct a personal living space as well as assist with the maintenance of the building and its public spaces. In an unwelcoming city, the squatters found a home.

Lisa Sroczyński, 19

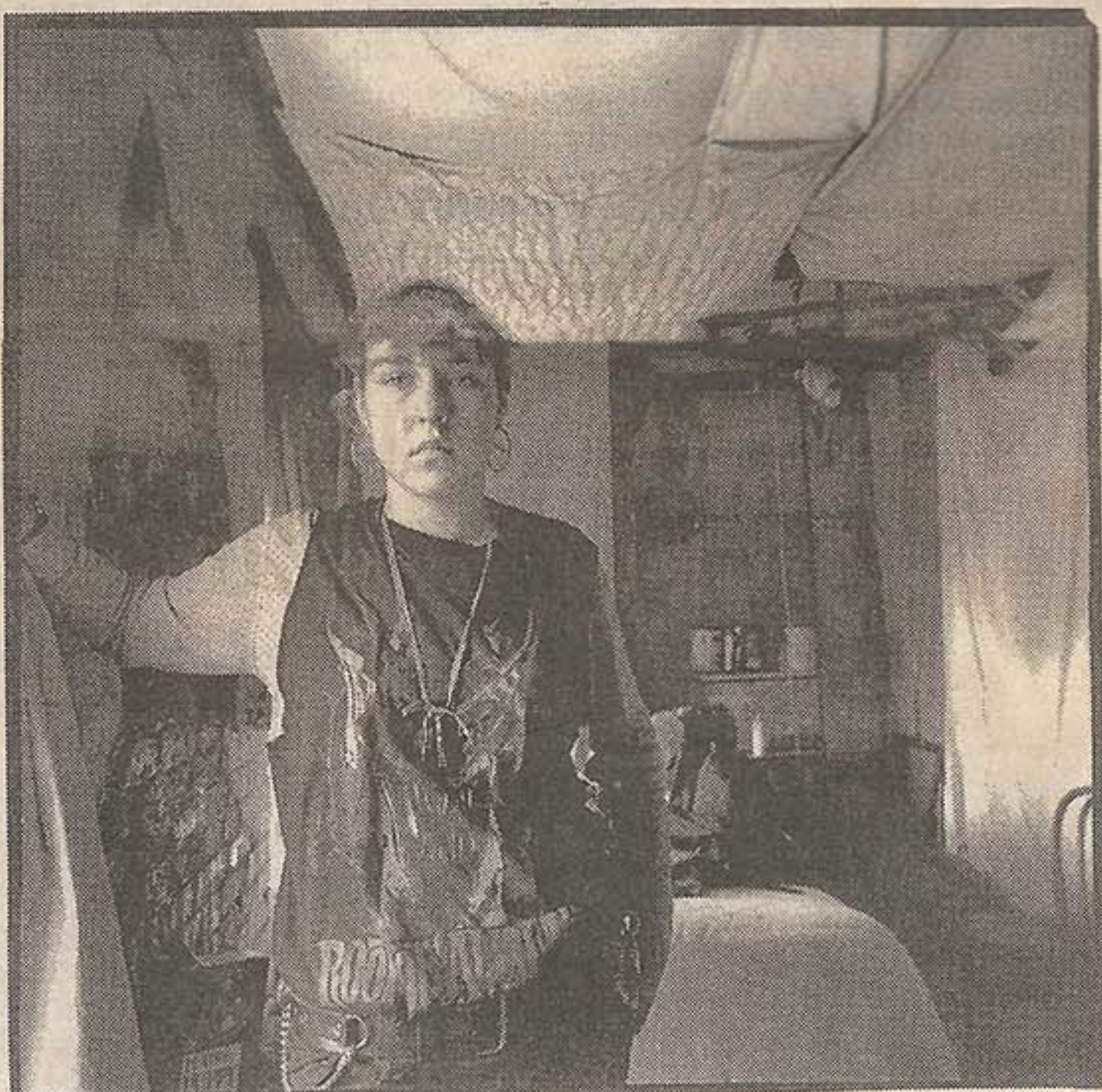
Right: Born in Ohio, left because of "a situation at home."

"There were a lot of people who had put in a lot of time and effort and really believed in the idea that the city has all these empty buildings that are just standing there and nobody's using them — and then there are all these people living out on the streets. Squatters don't come in and vandalize."

Calli Montroy, 18

Below: Left Long Island at 14, on her own ever since.

"When I came to Glass House, I was struggling with a drug problem. If it wasn't for the people supporting me, I wouldn't have stayed. They didn't want me to leave. They wanted me to straighten up. It was hard enough trying to kick it, but I was getting the chance to have people in my life who really cared."



Scott, 29

Above: Born in Ohio, a squatter at five New York sites since 1991.

"I finished high school but never got too far with college. To be part of the squatting community has meant an entire change in my life. I couldn't drive a damn nail before. I learned by doing it — building windows, building stairs. It's given me a lot of self-esteem. It's given me pride that I didn't have before."

Karl Rosenstein, 42

Left: College dropout from New Jersey, longtime political activist.

"I lived on the streets and slept in the park. One day I banged on the door of an abandoned building and asked if they had any place for a homeless activist. I ended up at Glass House in '92. Glass House was a family. If there was an issue that had to be settled, we talked about it. We all voted."

